Controversial Literature

H 1472

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A. Background

The form subdivision ***--Controversial literature*** is used under headings for individual religions, sects or denominations, under religious and monastic orders, and under sacred works, for works that argue against or express opposition toward those groups or works. The practice of using the subdivision under headings for general religious and philosophical topics was discontinued in 1998. The practice of using the subdivision for works that argue either for or against the topic and of further subdividing it by ***--Pro*** or ***--Con*** was discontinued in 1972. The form subdivision ***--Apologetic works*** is used under names of religions or denominations for works explaining the religion or denomination and defending it against criticism from the outside. This instruction sheet provides guidelines for assigning the subdivisions ***--Controversial literature*** and ***--Apologetic works***.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Apologetics writings***.

B. Recent revisions

2026-04: Updated template. Added instructions related LCGFT implementation.

C. Definitions

Controversial literature: works that argue against or express opposition to sacred works or religious organizations and their beliefs, especially those written by authors from outside the group being discussed.

Apologetic works: works explaining a religion, denomination, sect, etc., and defending it against criticism from the outside.

D. Religions, denominations, etc.

Use the free-floating form subdivision ***--Controversial literature*** under religions and their sects, Christian denominations, and monastic and religious orders for works that express opposition to these organizations and their beliefs, especially those written by authors from outside the group being discussed. Do not interpose another form or topical subdivision between the name of the religion and the subdivision ***--Controversial literature***.

Examples:

```
650 #0 $a Buddhism $v Controversial literature.
610 20 $a Catholic Church $v Controversial literature.
610 20 $a Jesuits $v Controversial literature.
```

For works explaining a religion or denomination and defending it against criticism from the outside, use the free-floating form subdivision ***--Apologetic works*** under the name of the religion or denomination.

LC practice: Assign a subject heading with the appropriate topical subdivisions. Do not assign the form subdivisions ***--Controversial literature*** and ***--Apologetic works***. Also assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Apologetics writings ***.

Examples:

```
Title: Searching for sense : the logic of Catholic belief.
   610 20 $a Catholic Church $v Apologetic works.
LC practice:
   610 20 $a Catholic Church $x Doctrines.
   655 #7 $a Apologetic writings. $2 lcgft


Title: A defense of Judaism versus proselytizing Christianity.
   650 #0 $a Christianity $v Controversial literature.
   650 #0 $a Judaism $v Apologetic works.
LC practice:
   650 #0 $a Christianity.
   650 #0 $a Judaism.
   655 #7 $a Apologetic writings. $2 lcgft
```

```
655 #7 $a Religious materials. $2 lcgft
```

E. Sacred works

Use the free-floating form subdivision ***--Controversial literature*** under sacred works or their individual parts for works that express opposition to these writings, question their authoritativeness, dispute their divine inspiration, etc. Do not interpose another form or topical subdivision between the uniform title and the subdivision ***--Controversial literature***.

LC practice: Assign a subject heading with the appropriate topical subdivisions. Do not assign the form subdivisions ***--Controversial literature*** and ***--Apologetic works***. Also assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Religious materials***.

Examples:

```
630 00 $a Bible. $p Genesis $v Controversial literature.

[not   630 00 $a Bible. $p Genesis $x Inspiration $v Controversial
       literature.]
```

LC practice:

```
630 00 $a Bible. $p Genesis.

655 #7 $a Religious materials. $2 lcgft


630 00 $a Book of Mormon $v Controversial literature.
```

LC practice:

```
630 00 $a Book of Mormon.

655 #7 $a Religious materials. $2 lcgft
```

Revision history

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